

Working With the Agent

Twelve habits for MP2 and beyond

HCDE 530 · SP26

01 Setting Up the Work

02 Working With the Agent

03 Catching Mistakes

TIP 1**Convert source documents to markdown first**

Before pasting a brief, transcript, or article into the agent, convert it to .md. PDFs and Word docs carry formatting the agent doesn't need and sometimes gets wrong. The markdown tool handles most file types in one command.

TIP 2**Keep your .cursorrules file alive**

You wrote one in Week 2. Update it as MP2 takes shape — what you're building, who it's for, what data it uses, what you've decided. The agent reads it automatically every conversation.

TIP 3**Use .md files as standing instructions**

Keep a project_notes.md or decisions.md in your repo. Log what you tried, what worked, what didn't. Reference it in prompts: "Read project_notes.md first, then help me with X." This is how you give the agent memory across sessions.

TIP 4**Scope context with @**

In Cursor, use @file, @folder, @codebase, and @docs to point the agent at exactly what it should look at. Don't dump the whole repo when you only need one file. Smaller, more specific context produces sharper output.

TIP 5**Start fresh every 10–15 turns**

10–15 turns is a reasonable upper limit, but the real signal is qualitative: when the agent starts repeating itself, contradicting earlier decisions, or losing the thread — start fresh. Carry forward what matters in your .md notes.

TIP 7**One change at a time**

Don't ask for three things in one prompt. The agent will do one well and the others badly, and you won't be able to tell which is which when you review the output. Sequence them.

TIP 6**Use Plan mode before edits**

Ask the agent for a plan before it touches any files. Read the plan. Push back on anything that looks wrong or overscoped. Approve only what you understand. This is where you catch bad moves cheaply — before they're in your files.

TIP 8**Explain before changing**

Before asking the agent to modify a file, ask it to explain what the file currently does. If the explanation is wrong, the change will be wrong. A 30-second explanation step catches misunderstandings before they become bugs.

TIP 9**Read every diff**

Cursor's accept-all button is a trap. Read each hunk. Accept hunks individually. If you don't understand a hunk, ask the agent to explain it before accepting — or reject it.

TIP 10**Commit before any big move**

Before asking the agent to restructure, reorganize, or add a sizable feature, commit your current state. If the big move goes sideways, you have a clean version to return to and haven't lost an hour of work.

TIP 11**When the agent loops, stop it**

If the agent has tried the same fix twice and failed, stop. Summarize what you actually know — the error, what you've tried, what hasn't worked — in your own words. Start a fresh conversation. Three minutes of human framing beats twenty minutes of agent retries.

TIP 12**Show, don't describe**

Paste the actual error message. Paste the actual file content. Paste the actual output. The agent can't see your screen, and a description is almost always less precise than the thing itself. Most stuck prompts unstuck the moment you paste the real artifact.

A few more things

● If you use Claude Code:

The `/context` command is the equivalent of Cursor's `@`-based scoping — it limits what the agent reads to the files you point it at.

● MCP servers:

MCP servers (e.g., Perplexity for web search inside the agent) exist and are worth knowing about. Look them up if you need them for MP2 — they have setup overhead, so don't start one the night before a deadline.

● MP2 submission — commit everything:

Your `.cursorsrules` file, `project_notes.md`, and any other `.md` files belong in your GitHub repo. They show how you managed the agent, not just what you built. Include them in your final commit.